

I made more money this past year than in any other year of my life, and it helped me that when that happened, I didn't panic. I didn't anxiously, compulsively spend it all. I paid down most of my debts: medical debt, credit card debt, auto loan, two of my three student loans. I started saving a little for retirement. I still have a constantly fluctuating amount in my savings account. I've still somehow acquired more credit card debt through my continued irresponsibility. I am far from perfect and still mess up ALL THE TIME.

But I let go of the total power money had over my psyche. Money isn't this huge, secret monster anymore. *Everyone* has intense emotions and unique problems connected to money. We all have to face and think about and use money. Even if we moved to the woods, I assume there'd be some sort of bartering system we'd have to set up with the deer and the squirrels.

Our money scripts aren't carved into stone. I've worked hard to change mine. Where we start off can't be helped. What can be helped is how we feel about it and how we address it.

Once we do that, we can stop individualizing issues that are collective. There are deep systemic reasons that large swaths of people are all on uneven footing. Everyone who has the time and means, especially upper-middle-class millennials and Gen Z, needs to be on top of legislation, elections, and economic and financial news. The larger system and those in power want us to internalize shame and fear around money, beat ourselves up, and believe the propaganda that the rich deserve their wealth and the poor deserve to struggle instead of looking outward at the fucked-up status quo.

It's hard to spend an entire book both giving advice and telling you the cards are stacked against you. After all that, it's even harder to say the solution is to rise up, join hands, and suddenly inject everyone on the planet with some much-needed empathy. There should be a middle ground. One where personal responsibility takes into account all the systemic factors. Where we don't shame low-income people for "moral failings" that are due in large part to histories of oppression and classist legislation. (And for God's sake, let them buy whatever they want.)

We can pay off our student loans while knowing that taking them out in the first place may not be the best path for our children and while advocating